

Scrolling through everyone else's good moments and feeling like your life fell short

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

A feed shows the slice of someone's life built to get a reaction, so you end up measuring your whole life against **their best hour**. Most people's struggles stay invisible, even friends you know well.

THE GOAL

You're getting out of the comparison rather than posting your way even with everyone. Name the exact post that set this off, whose it was and what kind.

CHECKLIST

The moment right after you stop scrolling: thumb still hovering, the feed still open, and you already feel like everyone else is doing better than you.

- ☐ Close the app or tab all the way; don't leave the feed open where the next post is one flick away.
- ☐ Name the exact post that set this off: whose it was, and what kind of post it was.
- ☐ Say which is true: still reachable, past its window, or not something you're chasing.
- ☐ If it's not something you're chasing, write "not my race" next to it and leave it there.
- ☐ If it's still reachable, write one concrete step you could take on it this week.
- ☐ If you've already missed that window, write the real reason down next to it.
- ☐ Write down one true, unremarkable thing from your own day: what you did, ate, or dealt with.
- ☐ Message or call one person you know well and ask a specific question about their actual week.
- ☐ If you're about to post or share something of your own right now, stop and put the phone down instead.
- ☐ Do one small physical thing instead, like making a drink or stepping outside for the length of one song.
- ☐ Give yourself a limit for sitting with this, like until the kettle boils or the song ends.
- ☐ Go back to the specific thing you were doing before you opened the app, and pick it back up.
- ☐ If one particular account keeps doing this to you, open the app just long enough to mute or unfollow it, then close it again.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Posting something impressive right now might not even things out. One review treats this as a plausible pattern, not a tested one: it may just hand the envy on to whoever scrolls past next.
- 2** Most people badly misjudge how hard things are for everyone around them, **even for friends they actually know well**: they underestimate the struggle and overestimate how good things are.
- 3** Seeing someone doing far better than you only motivates you when their success **still feels within reach**. When it doesn't, the same success discourages you instead, and neither reaction is a verdict on you.

What's driving that feeling

DON'T

Posting something impressive right now might not even things out. One review treats this as a plausible pattern, not a tested one: it may just hand the envy on to whoever scrolls past next.

One review offers this as an example of a possible pattern, not something it tested or observed. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Scrolling without posting or commenting carries a measured, specific cost: it lowers your mood by raising envy. That drop shows up no matter how much real, in-person contact you're also getting.

People who mostly scrolled instead of posting felt worse afterward **specifically through rising envy**, separate from any drop in real contact. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Online, what you're scrolling through is dominated by trips and travel, far more than anything else. Offline that same category still shows up, just far less often, next to job success and ability.

People describing a recent envy incident named travel and leisure far more often online than for everyday envy. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Vacation photos are the accepted way to show a good life without it reading as bragging.

Showing off directly through money or purchases risks looking like bragging, so the same self-promotion travels through photos of trips instead. [Source 3](#)

What's normal, and what it costs to miss

KNOW

Most people badly misjudge how hard things are for everyone around them, **even for friends they actually know well**: they underestimate the struggle and overestimate how good things are.

People rating a close friend's week consistently guessed less struggle and more good feeling than that friend reported, even though they saw them often. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

The more you assume others have it easier, the lower your own reported satisfaction tends to be.

The study found this same link twice: guessing others struggle less went with feeling worse, and separately, guessing they're happier also went with feeling worse. [Source 4](#)

Reach and relevance decide how a comparison lands

WATCH

Seeing someone doing far better than you only motivates you when their success **still feels within reach**. When it doesn't, the same success discourages you instead, and neither reaction is a verdict on you.

College students inspired by a successful peer believed they could still reach that success themselves; those who felt deflated believed the chance had already passed. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

A win only touches how you see yourself when it's in an area you're trying to build. In an unrelated field, the same success leaves your self-view untouched.

Students' self-ratings shifted after reading about a top performer in their own field, but held steady for a performer in a different field. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. https://ppw.kuleuven.be/okp/_pdf/Verduyn2017DSNSE.pdf
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Comparing yourself to others at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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